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Citizenship: Canada, USA



HARVARD
UNIVERSITY

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Education

Harvard University

Ph.D. Public Policy, 2020 to 2026 (expected)

Carleton College

B.A. Economics, *magna cum laude*, 2018

Fields

Primary Field: Labour Economics

Secondary Fields: Economic History, Political Economy, Development Economics

References

Professor Will Dobbie	Professor Desmond Ang	Professor Claudia Goldin
Harvard Kennedy School	Harvard Kennedy School	Harvard University
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Job Market Paper

The Defender on the Move: Black Newspapers and the Great Migration

After 50 years of limited migration following emancipation, 1.5 million Black southerners made the journey north during the First Great Migration from 1915 to 1940. I examine whether information on northern life and jobs sparked Black migration using quasi-random variation in exposure to the Chicago Defender, the most prominent northern Black newspaper. Classifying the coverage of thousands of southern newspapers, I show that information about the North was limited prior to the Chicago Defender's entry in the mid-1910s. To reach southern readers, the Chicago Defender partnered with Black railway porters working for the Illinois Central railroad. In cities along the railroad, I find that individuals who lived near a porter were 33% more likely to migrate north than similar individuals who did not. These individuals pulled relatives to migrate, consistent with information diffusion across social networks, and moved to cities that received more coverage in articles, ads, and job postings. Counties with access to the Chicago Defender were 1.5 times more likely to form an NAACP branch and experienced 1.4 times fewer lynchings.

Working Papers

Paywalls (with Desmond Ang, Stephen Pettigrew, and Ben Schneer)

Through the 2010s, the news media landscape shifted from an ad-supported to a subscription-based model. What are the effects of the transition? We examine the impact of local newspaper paywalls on news consumption, online browsing behavior, and the implications for voting, economic knowledge, and community engagement. We assemble the most comprehensive database to date tracking the implementation of paywalls for the universe of U.S. daily newspapers. We show that local newspapers skew right-leaning compared to other online news sources and attract readers who are older, whiter, and higher income. We find a sharp drop in time spent reading local newspapers after paywalls are implemented and a compositional shift toward wealthier readers. Individuals shift news consumption toward national news websites with more left-leaning ideological slants, soft news, and entertainment media. These substitution patterns cascade into a host of downstream outcomes, including a leftward shift in local residents' voting behavior and decreased knowledge of local economic conditions and social activity.

State of Mind and Human Capital Formation: Evidence from Indian Schools (with Kevin Carney)

Around 83% of U.S. K-12 schools have implemented a social-emotional learning (SEL) curriculum, yet we have little evidence on their efficacy. We study the effects of India's "Happiness Curriculum," the world's largest SEL curriculum, reaching millions of students in grades 1–8. The Happiness Curriculum replaces the first 30 minutes of each school day with guided mindfulness meditation followed by stories and activities designed to help students understand their thoughts, emotions, and relationships. We conduct a randomized control trial in partnership with the state of Tripura following over 4,000 students for 2 years. We randomly assign grades to receive either the Happiness Curriculum, daily mindfulness practice, or teaching-as-usual. Students' math scores in SEL and mindfulness grades increase by 0.12 SD after 6 months and 0.29 SD after 2 years, equivalent to an additional year of learning. Math gains are driven by daily mindfulness practice and likely operate through improved reasoning and problem-solving. We observe little effect on measures of anxiety or depression. Our results reveal that programs targeting state of mind can be cost-effective ways to improve academic achievement.

Papers in Progress	Blowin' in the Wind: The Impact of Climate Disasters on College Majors and Innovation (with Chloe Tanaka)
Other Publications or Working Papers	The Effect of Education on Later Life Health Revisited (with Ted Figinski and Alicia Lloro), <i>FEDS Working Paper 2022-007</i> How Does Social Distancing Affect the Spread of Covid-19 in the United States? (with Bhashkar Mazumder), <i>Chicago Fed Letter No. 442</i>, 2020
Teaching	Race and the State: The Role of Public Policy in U.S. Racial Inequality, Harvard Kennedy School Course Assistant for Professor Desmond Ang, 2023 Intermediate Price Theory, Carleton College Teaching Assistant for Professor Jenny Bourne, 2017-2018 Introduction to Macroeconomics, Carleton College Teaching Assistant for Professor Nathan Grawe, 2016 Introduction to Microeconomics, Carleton College Teaching Assistant for Professors Nathan Grawe and Prathi Seneviratne, 2015-2016
Relevant Experience	Research Assistant, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago, 2018-2020 Summer Intern, U.S. Department of Treasury, Office of Economic Policy, 2017 Summer Analyst, Cornerstone Research, 2016
Fellowships & Awards	Stone Ph.D. Scholar in Inequality and Wealth Concentration, Harvard Kennedy School, 2022 Ph.D. Affiliate of Centre for International Development, Harvard Kennedy School, 2022 Ph.D. Affiliate of Evidence for Policy Design, Harvard Kennedy School, 2022 Doctoral Fellow of Harvard Environmental Economics Program, Harvard Kennedy School, 2020 Top Undergraduate Senior Thesis, Minnesota Economics Association, 2018 Ada M. Harrison Prize in Economics, Carleton College, 2018 Phi Beta Kappa, Carleton College, 2018 Dean's List, Carleton College, 2016-2017
Research Grants	The Weiss Fund, with Kevin Carney, 2025 (\$14,343) Development Innovation Ventures, with Kevin Carney and Labhya Foundation, 2024 (\$910,000) Stone Research Grant, 2024 (\$1,670) Fund for Innovation in Development, with Kevin Carney and Labhya Foundation, 2023 (\$680,530) J-PAL Learning for All Initiative, with Kevin Carney, 2023 (\$43,276) The Weiss Fund, with Kevin Carney, 2023 (\$50,000) Stone Research Grant, 2023 (\$2,500)

Mind Brain and Behaviour Initiative, 2022 (\$10,000)
J-PAL Post-Primary Education Initiative, 2021 (\$31,724)

**Seminars &
Conferences**

Harvard Program on Democracy and the Informed Public, April 2026
Harvard Stone Scholar Symposium, April 2026
Harvard Shorenstein Centre on Media, Politics, and Public Policy, December 2025
Southern Economic Association, November 2025
London School of Economics Graduate Economic History Seminar, October 2025
Harvard Kennedy School Economics and Social Policy Seminar, September 2025
Harvard Economic History Seminar, September 2025
Harvard History, Culture, and Society Workshop, April 2025
Harvard Labour/Public Graduate Student Workshop, March 2025
Harvard Environmental Economics Graduate Student Workshop, March 2023
Harvard Centre for International Development Ph.D. Retreat, February 2023

Academic Service

Referee for American Journal of Health Economics, Journal of Policy Analysis and Management
Chair of Harvard Kennedy School Ph.D. Mentorship and Wellness Committees, 2020-2023

Languages

English (native), French (intermediate)

Software skills

Stata, Python, ArcGIS, R, LaTeX, RATS